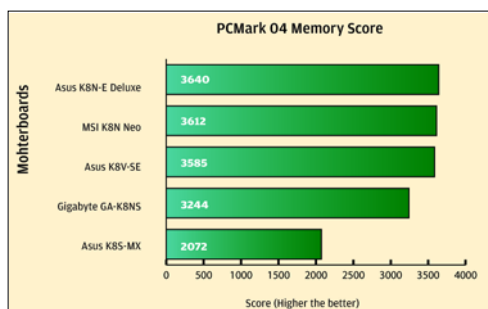




motherboard. Since the memory controllers for some of the Athlons are on the processors, the difference that is seen is due to the physical routing of the memory bus rather than anything else.

Performance Of The I/O Sub-systems

Asus' K8N-E Deluxe maintains its lead by a significant margin. Gigabyte's GA-K8NS takes the second position, while the ASUS K8S-MX is right on its tail. The Asus K8V-SE Deluxe loses out to these boards. Interestingly, the better-performing K8N Neo Platinum from MSI slips to last spot, thus that it is not the motherboard to be considered if your work involves lots of data processing.

Overall, we can conclude that the nForce 3 250 GB chipset is superior to the VIA and SiS solutions by a long shot.

3DMark 2003

In this benchmark, MSI's K8N Neo takes first place, displacing the ASUS K8N-E Deluxe. However, the difference is no more than 0.5 per cent, which can effectively be ignored. Gigabyte's GA-K8NS takes third position, and is closely followed by Asus' K8V-SE, while its cost-effective sibling, the K8S-MX, is put down where it belongs. This test once again proves the superiority of the nForce 3 chipset over its close competitor from VIA.

DOOM 3

With DOOM 3, Asus' K8N-E deluxe comes first. Asus' K8V-SE outshines Gigabyte's GA-K8NS to take the second slot. MSI's K8N Neo is

on par with Gigabyte's board, whereas Asus' SiS connection once again fails to fire. Overall, all motherboards put up a good show here.

Conclusion

Going by pure performance, the competition between the ASUS K8N-E

Deluxe and MSI's K8N Neo is close. However, the Asus surges ahead, by a small margin. On the features front, both boards are on par, and that leaves us with price to decide who takes the crown. The MSI K8N Neo is about Rs 800 cheaper than the Asus K8N-E Deluxe. However, we think they both deserve accolades and are equally good solutions for AMD's socket 754 pin processor.

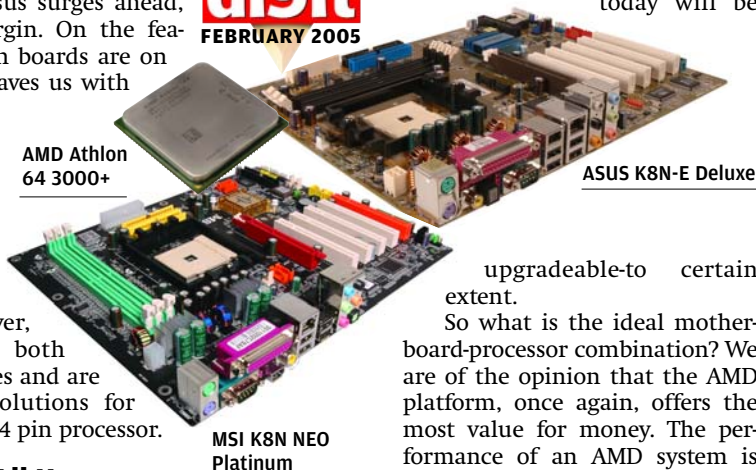
Summing It All Up

In our processor test, we witnessed AMD's Athlon64 processor take the steam out of the Pentium 4 series of processors. If you want the best performance, nothing beats the Athlon 64 line.

In the motherboard test, we saw the successful inception of PCI-Express on the Intel platform, which was not the case with AMD-the platform still relies on the AGP and PCI standards.

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AMD Athlon
64 3000+



ASUS K8N-E Deluxe

upgradeable-to certain extent.

So what is the ideal motherboard-processor combination? We are of the opinion that the AMD platform, once again, offers the most value for money. The performance of an AMD system is way ahead of Intel's competing products, is on equal footing as per features, and costs less.

We award the Athlon64 3000+ and ASUS K8N-E Deluxe or MSI K8N Neo Platinum as the best buy Gold solution. This combo in conjunction with appropriate components will work great for gamers, for professional artists using resource-intensive applications such as Photoshop, 3D Max, Maya, etc, and will cost no more than Rs 15,000.

If you are on a shoestring budget and Rs 15,000 is too much to spend, go for the AMD Sempron 3100+ and ASUS K8S-MX. This combo will cost around Rs 11,000. Since the board has integrated video and an AGP slot, you can opt to save on cost, and at the same time, have the option of upgrading later. This combination wins our best buy Silver award.

For the 'Intel Inside' devotees, the Pentium 4 530 (3 GHz) combined with Gigabyte's 8I915G Duo makes the ideal motherboard-processor combo at Rs 17,000. Overall, on a performance-and-features scale, this combination lies somewhat between our Gold and Silver awardees, but costs more. ☐

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AMD Sempron
3100+



ASUS K8S-MX

Contact Sheet

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GIGABYTE	Cyberstar	0-9323809599	navin@cyberstarindia.com	www.msi.com.tw
MSI	Tirupati Enterprises	0-98310022600	abhishek@tirupati.net	www.msi.com.tw
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